



Deutsche
Sporthochschule Köln
German Sport University Cologne

COARA ACTION PLAN 2025-2029



Mission Statement:

As of 2023, the German Sport University Cologne (GSU) has dedicated itself to the principles of the European Coalition on Reforming Research Assessment (CoARA). Demonstrating this commitment, GSU officially became a member in February 2024 by signing the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA).

By aligning with CoARA's core values, the GSU aims to actively reshape how research, researchers, and research institutions are evaluated. The goal is to cultivate a system that genuinely values the diverse range of research outputs, methodologies, and contributions, ultimately elevating the quality and broader impact of scholarly work.

The GSU's engagement within the Coalition is multifaceted, encompassing both internal action and external collaboration. Internally, this Action Plan details the specific initiatives GSU will implement to fulfil its CoARA pledges, demonstrating a firm commitment to reforming its own research assessment practices. Externally, GSU actively participates within the German National CoARA Chapter, directly shaping its projects and contributing to its deliverables.

Furthermore, GSU's commitment to the reform of research assessment is supported by the Volkswagen Foundation. This project, entitled "Implementation of ARRA at Universities - Development of a Best Practice Toolbox", addresses the following commitments in addition to those outlined in the table below:

- Commitment 5 by providing resources for this reform.
- Commitment 8 by exchanging practices and experiences with the project team. In addition, this funding enables a collaboration with Bielefeld University to develop a practical toolbox, that can be used beyond the project team, supporting universities across Germany to implement ARRA and transform their research assessment practices.
- Commitment 9 by communicating the progress and results of the project within the German National CoARA Chapter and at Conferences.

Building upon its existing commitment to the "HR Excellence in Research" (HRS4R) framework, the GSU recognizes the inherent alignment between the HRS4R principles and the CoARA commitments. As such, GSU will ensure strong synergy and continuous integration between the actions outlined in this CoARA Action Plan and those developed within its regular HRS4R action plans. These complementary plans are fully endorsed by the university's leadership and are embedded within the broader framework of the institution's strategic planning, reflecting a comprehensive dedication to these values.

Governance:

A steering team consisting of Dr. Dinah Nockemann, Dr. Claudia Combrink, Dr. Alexandra Pizzera, and Dr. Nina Ferrari manages the CoARA initiative at GSU. The steering team reports to the Rectorate on a regular basis and integrates relevant committees (e.g., Research and Transfer Commission, Senate) in the reform process.

Action Plan:

The Action Plan is based on the work packages that are to be implemented as part of the project funded by the Volkswagen Foundation and also includes long-term evaluation and adaptation processes. In principle, the Action Plan should be seen as a living document and as such, can be updated any time within the 4-year time frame according to monitoring carried out by GSU.

Action	Related to CoARA Commitments	Responsibility	Deadline
<u>Action 1: Awareness Raising</u> Goal: Creating awareness and acceptance of the need to reform research assessment within the GSU community. Actions: • Organization of information events, workshops, and discussion forums for all status groups (researchers, students, administrative staff). • Development of target group-specific communication materials (e.g., brochures, FAQs, videos) in German and English. • Establishment of a website with information on the goals, principles, and progress of the initiative. • Integration of the topic into existing communication channels (e.g., newsletter, intranet). ⇒ Laying the groundwork for a cultural shift that embraces qualitative assessment as the primary basis for evaluating research merit and impact. This foundational work is essential for the subsequent actions to be effective and sustainable.	• Commitment 2 (Basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgment) • Commitment 4 (Avoiding the use of rankings of research organizations) • Commitment 7 (Raising awareness of research assessment reform and providing guidance and training)	CoARA steering team	Ongoing
<u>Action 2: GAP Analysis</u> Goal: Identifying gaps in the reform process and highlighting synergies with other processes. Actions: • Conduct a comprehensive analysis of current research assessment practices at GSU. • Compare current practices with the goals and principles of ARRA. • Identify areas where current practices do not align with ARRA goals.	• Commitment 1 (recognizing the diversity of contributions to research) • Commitment 2 (Basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgment) • Commitment 3 (Abandoning inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics) • Commitment 4 (Avoiding the use of rankings of research organizations)	CoARA steering team	Q1 2026

- Highlight potential synergies with ongoing initiatives such as HRS4R and the Open Science Policy. - Preparation of a report with the results of the GAP analysis and recommendations for further actions. ⇒ Systematically identifying where current assessment practices at GSU may overlook or undervalue diverse forms of research output (e.g., datasets, software, community engagement, policy impact, teaching). The GAP analysis will reveal discrepancies between GSU's stated values and its current assessment practices, allowing for targeted interventions.			
Action 3: Development of Tools and Criteria Goal: Development and adaptation of tools and criteria for qualitative and diverse research assessments, involving all relevant stakeholders. Actions: - Development of criteria catalogues, guidelines, and good-practice examples for qualitative research assessment. - Consideration of open science practices, research integrity, equality, and diversity in the development of assessment criteria. ⇒ The new instruments will promote a more holistic and qualitative evaluation of research impact, considering a broader range of outputs (e.g., datasets, software, community engagement, policy influence) and focusing on the quality and significance of the research.	Commitment 2 (Basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgment) Commitment 3 (Abandoning inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics) Commitment 6 (Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes)	CoARA steering team Relevant stakeholders such as researchers, committees, working units like Open Science and Equality, as well as administrative staff.	Q1 2027
Action 4: Testing of Developed Tools and Criteria Goal: Gradual, long-term, and sustainable implementation of the developed tools and criteria. Actions: Piloting of the developed tools in selected areas of GSU.	Commitment 2 (Basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgement) Commitment 4 (Avoiding the use of rankings of research organizations) Commitment 6 (Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes)	CoARA steering team	Q1 2028

• Obtaining feedback from researchers and other stakeholders on the developed tools. • Training of reviewers and decision-makers in the application of the new assessment criteria or processes. • Support and guidance of the pilot projects by the steering team. ⇒ This testing phase will evaluate the practicality and effectiveness of the new tools and processes with respect to the promotion of a more qualitative approach to research assessment across GSU.			
Action 5: Evaluation and Adaptation Goal: Continuous, systematic evaluation and adaptation of the impact of the implemented tools and criteria on research quality at GSU. Actions: • Conducting surveys, interviews, and focus groups with the involved stakeholders. • Analysing the impact of the new assessment criteria on the quality and diversity of research. • Continuous adaptation and optimization of the tools and criteria based on long-term observations and feedback from stakeholders. ⇒ Through systematic evaluation, GSU will collect data on how well the new assessment methods are capturing the quality of research as well as diverse outputs (e.g. datasets, software, community engagement, etc.) and identifying unintended biases or gaps.	• Commitment 10 (Evaluate practices, criteria, and tools based on solid evidence)	CoARA steering team	ongoing